



A WORK BY SHETTY

EXHIBITION

Art in MOTION

Exploring new frontiers with his installations and photo montages, Mumbai-based artist Sudarshan Shetty has been at the forefront of the experimental wave in Indian art. With his latest exhibition *Six Drops*, which is a series of 56 inkjet prints on Hahnemuhle bamboo paper, Shetty moves in a new direction and conceptualises a show that is "virtual and animated rather than centred around objects". With a focus on movement, the series explores large, small, static and moving products and spaces. These six drops are said to represent the six mythic enemies within the self that revitalise both the artistic self and the institutional realm. At Gallery SKE in Bangalore. On till May 25.

by *Nirmala Ravindran*

DANCE

Out of Step

Dancers are a disgruntled lot. At the first opportunity they get, they voice their concerns, be it at a seminar, a workshop or any other forum. A recent meet organised by Natyavriksha in Delhi was no exception only it was packaged differently. As the seminar dwelt on the dwindling appeal of dance, it highlighted the need for better marketing. Sanjoy Roy of Teamwork Films said packaging and marketing are no more dirty words. Having successfully presented dancers at Edinburgh festival, he felt dance held much scope for hardsell. "We presenters need to think of buyers," he argued. At a time when dancers are battling for an audience, the need to reinvent their art is being increasingly felt. "If Bollywood dancing is spectacular, so can be classical. Only it has to be crafted differently," says Geeta Chandran.

Dancers realise it is not easy to survive amid market forces acting against them. "On our visits abroad, we find the missions ill-equipped to handle dancers. They sometimes have no clue about dance or its forms," says Chandran. "Dancers are taken for granted," says Anita Ratnam, a contemporary dancer, who says she was once asked to give 15 performances in 18 days, which she politely refused.

Dance as a career is fast losing appeal, feel many dancers. "Delhi has the most number of dancers with a

good network but what about dancers in far-flung areas and dance forms like Satriya and Manipuri? They continue to be neglected," says Jayant Kastuar, secretary, Sangeet Natak Akademi.

The other handicap, the dancers say, is of good accompanists. "We are at the mercy of a few who not only blackmail us but the NRIs get preference over Indians and we are left high and dry," insists a dancer. "But if you have the passion and don't crave foreign trips, other doors will open," says Roy. There is another threat of traditional dancers getting diluted in the name of popularising dance. "If we start diluting the traditional forms then it

will no longer remain classical. It will end up like performances in reality shows on TV," says Bharatanatyam dancer Ragini Chander Shekhar. It's a frightening proposition.

by *S. Sahaya Ranjit*

RAGINI CHANDER SHEKHAR

